

Chapter 67-1

—Why would you go provoke a lunatic who would personally kill her own daughter?

This statement shocked Liang Shi far more than the latter one.

Liang Shi looked at Qiu Zimin in astonishment, opening her mouth with difficulty: "You're saying her daughter was killed by her own hand?"

"If you know, then stop provoking her." Qiu Zimin sneered coldly, "Liang Shi, you should know that leaving you alive is already my mercy."

"But why would Yang Jiani kill her own daughter? Where did the current daughter come from? Why hasn't anyone questioned this? Can there really be two identical people in this world?" Liang Shi struck while the iron was hot.

Qiu Zimin looked at her, her voice suddenly softening, carrying a hint of laziness and mockery, "Liang Shi, stop trying to dig for information from me. Some things—the more you know, the faster you die."

The last few words were spoken almost syllable by syllable, sounding like a threat.

"We're a society ruled by law." Liang Shi sneered coldly, "Does your upper-class society not follow the law?"

"We do, we're the most law-abiding group of people." Qiu Zimin glanced at her lightly: "But there are too many accidents in this world. You can't possibly avoid encountering an accident for your entire life."

Liang Shi: "....."

She exhaled lightly, "So the current Qi Jiao was adopted?"

"What does it have to do with you?" Qiu Zimin snorted coldly: "Instead of having the effort to worry about others, you'd better worry more about what you'll do in the future."

Liang Shi looked at her, knowing she couldn't get any information about Yang Jiani and Qi Jiao from her, so she changed direction: "So did you see Daoist Master Yunyin¹ that day?"

"I didn't." Qiu Zimin said: "I'm tired."

She glanced at Liang Shi's pocket, "You don't really think having a recording can prove anything, do you?"

Liang Shi's hand tightened slightly, but she suppressed her surprise, not lowering her head to look at her pocket. Instead, she pretended to be calm and smiled: "What do you mean?"

"Your phone." Qiu Zimin showed a mocking expression: "I stopped playing these tricks twenty years ago."

After suppressing the initial fear and trepidation, Liang Shi finally came to her senses.

She had unconsciously been following Qiu Zimin's emotional rhythm.

Liang Shi steadied her mind and said coldly: "Although the recording can't prove anything, it can guide public opinion."

Although Liang Shi had never thought of doing this, recording in advance was only for self-protection.

"As you wish." Qiu Zimin curved her lips in a cold smile, "Pushing your adoptive mother into the center of public opinion—Liang Shi, you really are something."

"We haven't reached that point yet." Liang Shi brushed off the specks of dust on her clothes, "It's a bit early to say such things."

"I need to rest." Qiu Zimin returned to that elegant posture, glancing at Liang Shi arrogantly: "Close the door on your way out."

Liang Shi walked toward the exit, but paused when she reached the door, "Have you ever thought about what your children would do if they knew your true face?"

"My true face?" Qiu Zimin laughed lowly, her voice faint, carrying a hint of coldness: "What is my true face? Vicious? A venomous woman?"

"You know yourself." Liang Shi said: "Those things you've done....."

"What have I done?" Qiu Zimin retorted: "Can't a mother be foolishly superstitious? Can't she be deceived by others?"

"Liang Shi." Qiu Zimin said: "No matter what, I raised you all these years, and now you turn around and bite the hand that fed you, and you even want to stand on the moral high ground to call me vicious. You should look in the mirror and see whose heart is truly black!"

Liang Shi's breathing tightened.

For a moment, she almost doubted whether her approach was correct.

It seemed that after Qiu Zimin put it that way, she really was quite despicable.

How could she say those things and do those things to the adoptive mother who worked so hard to raise her?

Even resistance shouldn't be allowed.

But it was only for a moment.

A moment later, Liang Shi turned her back to her and smiled helplessly with a bitter smile, sighing softly: "Your rhetoric is indeed impressive."

But she was no longer the original Liang Shi.

However, after this encounter, Liang Shi came to appreciate even more how terrifying Qiu Zimin was.

This person wasn't simply bad or stupid; on the contrary, she was very clever.

She could give you information, but would never let her vulnerabilities fall into your hands.

She would hysterically scold you, insult you, and oppress you from the moral high ground, but wouldn't give you the chance to insult her in return.

After all, she was the one who raised you. If you were a grateful child, you would never do these things.

It was precisely because of this that the original host had been so thoroughly dominated.

The original host went crazy and acted badly without restraint, but would never harm the Liang family's related interests.

And in front of Qiu Zimin, she was as docile as a lamb. Occasionally she would bare her fangs, but would become obedient again because of those words.

If a child grew up under this kind of rhetoric, no matter what they became, it would seem natural.

Qiu Zimin looked at her innocently, "What rhetoric do I have? Are you going to say I'm gaslighting² you again? Don't just learn a trending internet term and apply it to me. Who changed you? Who told you that once you discovered I'm not your biological mother, you could turn around and question everything I've done? No matter what, I raised you. The grace of raising is greater than the grace of giving birth."

Liang Shi exhaled heavily and said without any flattery or ulterior motive: "You're very impressive."

A calm Qiu Zimin was in an invincible state.

Even in a palace intrigue drama³, she would be a ruthless character who could survive fifty episodes.

But she had a weakness.

Liang Shi said gently: "I hope your daughter hasn't encountered parents like you, the way I did."

"Just because someone raised you doesn't mean they can be called parents and deserve gratitude." Liang Shi slowly turned her head, her eyes containing a bright light, "After all, no parent would want to cultivate their own child into a psychopath and send them to a psychiatric hospital."

"Shut up!" Mentioning her biological daughter, Qiu Zimin suddenly became emotional, "My Nannan⁴ would never be like you, unable to distinguish right from wrong! So ungrateful!"

Liang Shi smiled gently and calmly asked back: "Is that so?"

Qiu Zimin threw a cushion at her, "Get out! All these years you've stolen her position, occupied the love that should have been hers, and now you're here to maliciously speculate about her! Get out! This family has no room for you!"

Liang Shi bent down, extended her long arm to catch the cushion, her voice still gentle but firm and powerful, "Ms. Qiu, under the sunlight, darkness will ultimately have nowhere to hide."

When sunlight shines down, there may be shadows.

But as long as it's bright enough and righteous enough, the shadows will no longer exist.

Footnotes:

¹ Daoist Master Yunyin: A Daoist priest or master. Daoism (also spelled Taoism) is a traditional Chinese philosophy and religion. Religious practitioners often use titles like "Daoshi" (道士, Daoist priest) or "Daozhang" (道长, Daoist Master). "Yunyin" (云隐) means "Cloud Hidden."

² Gaslighting: The original Chinese uses "PUA" (Pick-Up Artist), which in Chinese internet culture has evolved to mean psychological manipulation and emotional abuse, similar to gaslighting. The term is used to describe manipulative behavior in relationships where one person undermines another's perception of reality.

³ Palace intrigue drama: Known as "gongdou ju" (宫斗剧) in Chinese, these are historical dramas centered on power struggles, scheming, and survival tactics among concubines and imperial family members in ancient Chinese palaces. They typically feature intelligent, calculating characters who use manipulation and strategy to survive.

⁴ Nannan: An affectionate nickname meaning "daughter" or "little girl." The character 囡 (nān) is a dialectal term (particularly in Wu dialect regions like Shanghai) used as an endearing way to refer to a daughter or young girl. The repetition (囡囡) makes it even more affectionate.